

ONE-DAY CRICKET

Unlimited MANIA

Within two years of the introduction of limited-overs cricket in India, everything changed. The way Indians looked at the game and how the world looked at Indian cricket.

■ By Sharda Ugra

November 25, 1981, is not one of those, "where were you when..." dates. Nothing very memorable happened, nobody famous died. But on that day, India got its first look at this curious beast called "one-day cricket". The first ODI held in India was played at Ahmedabad's Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel Stadium, against England. India lost as you would, if you scored 156 in 46 overs.

Madhav Gothoskar remembers the day well. One of two nominated umpires for the game, his duties had included proof-reading the playing conditions hurriedly sent from Australia before they went to BCCI's printers. It was Gothoskar's first and only ODI game because Test umpires usually didn't stand in such non-serious stuff.

In Ahmedabad, he watched crowds packing in

under tents erected over the cheap stands. "They wouldn't stop coming, soon there were people sitting inside the boundary line." He says he knew it, then, two years before the World Cup victory, "that one-day cricket would take off in India".

The six-Test India-England series that served as main course in 1981 finished 1-0 to India and nobody seemed to mind. The pace of Test cricket suited India. An English reporter of the time purred appreciatively: "Cricket in India remains sensitive to the better traditions... the one-day game, which grows fast in other Test countries, holds no great attraction."

Talk about taking a sledgehammer to a stereotype. Within two years, Test cricket's appeal in India was obliterated by the sniff of the most powerful drug in the sporting world: victory.

CELEBRATED CHAMPS: Team India with the T20 World Cup at Johannesburg in September this year

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